



Silver
Solution Partner
US GOVERNMENT

LEVERAGING AGILE IN ATYPICAL PROJECTS

The high-level goals of the ERP CS program were to establish a core operating environment consisting of hardware, database, and the core Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) software to provide Common Services (CS). The various Air Force ERP systems could then use this core technology stack and develop solutions to their specific problems rather than repeat this hardware and software stack for each individual system. While an infrastructure and Commercial off-the-shelf (COTS) implementation is not the prototypical project that would be associated with an Agile methodology, there were several needs of the team that had to be addressed that weren't by Waterfall. The biggest challenges were the variable timeline associated with hardware acquisition and the changing priorities of the various partners that would be using the ERP CS platforms. The Scrum Framework was chosen to be utilized in the CCE program. By default, this method allowed the program to build a little, learn from that build and adjust accordingly, at a rapid pace. The process of defining and maintaining (grooming) the backlog ensured the most important requirements are addressed first with constant stakeholder involvement.

The Solution

As an Agile tool, the Atlassian suite of applications was a natural selection for use on the program. Initially, the program evaluated the services under the Defense Intelligence Information Enterprise. (DI2E) program. but the lack of options for workflow customizations, lack of Jira Service Desk, and support for the plugins the program needed drove the decision to stand up an internal implementation of Jira.

The three core products chosen to support ERP CS include Jira, Confluence, and Jira Service Desk (JSD) (now Jira Service Management (JSM).) Jira (specifically Jira Software) was chosen for its out of the box support of the Scrum Framework. Confluence was chosen to be a collaboration area that allowed teams to share information and link documentation and artifacts to Jira tickets. JSD was leveraged by the team in two ways. The first was as a mechanism for mission partners to raise support (including) change requests in a portal that was accessible by all partners. The service desk was also linked to a knowledge base where Standard Operating Procedures (SOP) could be located as a self-help mechanism. The JSD portal was also used internally by the team to report incidents and raise general Operations and Maintenance (O&M) requests such as restoring a database from a backup.

The Result

As the teams matured into scrum and utilizing Jira to manage and plan their work. The mentality shifted from Jira being a tool that was mandated for use into being leveraged to improve their work. Communication with the customer improved because they could see the work in-flight and planned across all the teams. Planning and estimation improved as teams leveraged Jira capabilities such as burn-down and velocity charts.

In the early stages, all teams utilized a scrum framework but it became apparent that several of the teams did not fit this mold because they had primarily recurring and repetitive tasks that did not fit a scrum team well. We were artificially forcing work into sprints and scrum boards when this was not the natural organization of these activities for these teams. These teams migrated to kanban boards which provided a process and workflow that made more sense for these teams.